When Your Mind Jumps to Conclusions

What am I being asked to believe — and what supports it?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1, especially its closing instruction; **Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 8.49**. Epictetus asks us to examine impressions and what is up to us. Marcus separates what is reported from what we add. An impression is how something appears; assent accepts what it presents as true.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question and reading links. Invite an ordinary example of a quick conclusion. Newcomers need no preparation.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	**Discuss · 40**	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	Test a message with no reply	**The questions below**	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. An important message has no reply. What do you know, and what might your mind add?
2. Which impressions feel most convincing before you examine them? Why?
3. What judgment or intention belongs to you, and what depends on someone else?
4. What evidence would justify accepting, rejecting, or leaving a conclusion unsettled?
5. If your first judgment stands after examination, what did the practice accomplish?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Test one impression. When certainty or urgency arrives, name the impression, separate what you know from what you infer, and decide what the grounds support. The judgment may stand, change, or stay unsettled. If you notice only afterward, you can still reopen it.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What supports that?" Ask it of reassuring interpretations too. The Fundamental Rule identifies your judgment and intention; another person's response still deserves care.

NOTES